enabled large numbers of Sapiens to cooperate. Corporations like Peugeot, laws like Hammurabi's Code, as well as human rights, money, gods and nations are all fictional stories we invented in order to enable billions of people to cooperate. It is thanks to these stories that we rule planet Earth, rather than the Neanderthals or the chimpanzees. Hitherto, nobody except us Sapiens could invent fictional stories. But now, AI can do it. Who knows what stories it will invent, and how they will change the world? Will AI create new corporations, new financial devices, new legal rights and new gods?

By mastering the art of storytelling, AI has hacked the operating system of human civilisation. This may well lead to the end of human history. Not the end of history – just the end of its human-dominated part. History is the interaction between biology and culture: between our biological needs and desires for things like food and sex, and our cultural creations like religions and laws. History is the process through which religions and laws shape food and sex.

What will happen to the course of history when AI takes over culture and begins producing stories, melodies, images, laws, and religions? Within a few years AI could eat the whole of human culture – everything we have created since the Stadel lion-man and the cave art of Chauvet – digest it and begin to gush out a flood of new cultural artefacts. At first, AI will probably imitate human cultural prototypes. But with each passing year, AI culture will boldly go where no human has gone before, especially because computers are free from the limitations that evolution and biochemistry impose on the human imagination. For millennia human beings have lived inside the dreams of other humans. We have worshipped gods, pursued ideals of beauty, and dedicated our lives to causes that originated in the imagination of some prophet, poet, or politician. In the coming decades we might find ourselves trapped inside the dreams of an alien intelligence.

This will take time, of course, so for a few more years we Sapiens are still in control. At present, we are the ones telling the story, and we can use this superpower to try to influence the next chapters, too. Every technology can be used for many different purposes, and we can yet shape the technology we are creating. In a century or two, Earth will be dominated by entities more different from us than we are different from Neanderthals or chimpanzees. But we Sapiens still have time to answer the question with which I ended the book in 2014: What do we want to want?